MICA Arm 3 — testing the text messages

Five alert tests + the weekly series · about 35 minutes · updated 23 September 2026

Five rules. Everything else is detail.

Rules 1 and 2 changed on 21 September. They are the two that fail *silently* — you get no text, and nothing anywhere tells you why.

1. **The phone number, the date and the SMS tick always go at *Arm 1's* Day 1 (ED)** — not at Arm 3's, even for the Arm 3 tests. Every participant is enrolled at Arm 1's Day 1 and only then placed into their arm, so that is the one event the reminders read. The record must still *be* in Arm 3 — that is what selects Arm 3's version — but its details live at Arm 1's Day 1.
2. **Then save something at the event the reminder itself belongs to.** Entering the date alone is not enough: REDCap only looks for due reminders at an event when something is saved *there*. Each test says which form, and where.
3. **One alert switched on at a time** — otherwise you cannot tell which one sent the text.
4. **Type any backdated date on your first save of the form.** REDCap fixes the send time then and never recalculates it. Get it wrong and you must start a new record.
5. **Never reply STOP to a test text** — it blocks your handset for the study permanently. Test 3 opts out safely, with a tickbox.

The texting account is live and every text really sends. Use your own mobile number, never a participant's.

Before you start — one-time checks

Ask the study team to confirm these. You cannot fix them yourself, and if any is wrong, no text will send.

CHECK	MUST BE
Alerts are in this project	**Alerts & Notifications** lists alerts numbered from **01 Phone check**
Texting scope	**"Surveys and Alerts"** — if it says "Surveys only", every alert here is silently undeliverable. Does not affect the weekly series (tests 6A and 6B), which uses its own texting module.
`phonen` field validation	**Phone** — without it REDCap will not use the field as a text recipient

The five tests at a glance

One fresh record per test. Note the arm — they differ. Two of the five pass by *nothing* arriving.

TEST	WHAT IT PROVES	RECORD'S ARM	DATE TO ENTER AT ARM 1'S DAY 1	THEN SAVE HERE	EXPECTED
1	Passcode confirms the phone number	**Arm 1**	none needed	Arm 1, Day 1	Text, immediately
2	Session reminder after one week	**Arm 3**	**today minus 7 days**	**Arm 3**, Day 1	Text, ~90 seconds
3	Opting out stops the texts	**Arm 3**	**today minus 7 days**	**Arm 3**, Day 1	**No text**
4	Finishing cancels the reminder	**Arm 3**	**today minus 7 days**	**Arm 3**, Day 1	**No text**
5	Booster reminder, Arm 3's version	**Arm 3**	**today minus 92 days**	**Arm 3**, Month 3	Text, ~90 seconds

Test 1 Passcode text

Confirms the phone number the participant gave us is really theirs

~5 min

SWITCH ON	**01 Phone check – passcode by SMS**
ARRIVES	Within seconds of saving. No waiting.
WHERE	**Arm 1 — Standard Care (SC)**, Day 1 (ED)

> **This one needs the participant survey actually completed.** Filling in `contact_info` as a coordinator and stopping there is *not* enough — the passcode is generated by a hidden calculation on that form, and until it has a value the alert is blocked. Work through the survey as a participant would, to the end.

1. `Add / Edit Records` → arm **Arm 1: Standard Care (SC)** → `Add new record`. **Write down the record number.**
2. Open the **Day 1 (ED)** event.
3. Open `consent`, fill enough to be plausible, status **Complete**, save.
4. Open `contact_info` and fill:

`first_name`	your first name
`phonen`	**your own mobile number**
`email`	your email address
`choice_fup_delivery`	tick **“SMS to [phonen]”**

5. Status **Complete** and save.
6. **Now complete the survey.** Open the participant survey link for this record and work through it to the end, rather than stopping at `contact_info`. The passcode is only generated once the survey run has produced it.

> **Then look at `calcrnd` before anything else.** It must show a **4-digit** number. That is the passcode, and the alert is **not allowed to send while it is blank** — you would get no text and no explanation. A blank `calcrnd` is the single most common reason this test appears to fail. If it is blank, the survey was not taken far enough; go back and finish it. If it shows **8 digits**, stop and tell the study team: a fix has not been applied to this project. All four must be true before a text goes out: `consent` Complete, `contact_info` Complete, `phonen` filled in, `calcrnd` showing four digits.

> **PASS** — a text arrives reading *“MICA: your verification passcode is NNNN…”*, and those four digits are the ones you just read in `calcrnd`.

7. **Finish the test.** Open `check_code`, type those four digits into `passcode`, save. `calc_code_check` must show **1** and the page must show the “code correct” message. The text arriving is only half the requirement.

> **Sends once per record, ever.** Re-saving will not produce a second text. To run this test again, create a new record.

Test 2 Session reminder after one week

Nudges a participant randomised a week ago who has not done their MICA session

~5 min

SWITCH ON	**03 MICA ED session 1-week reminder (SMS)** — and switch test 1's alert off
ARRIVES	Within about 90 seconds. REDCap checks for due reminders once a minute.
WHERE	Details at **Arm 1's** Day 1 (ED); the record sits in **Arm 3**

1. **Add / Edit Records** → arm **Arm 1: Standard Care (SC)** → **Add new record**. Note the number. Open **Day 1 (ED)**. Yes, Arm 1 — rule 1. The record moves to Arm 3 in step 4.
2. On `admin`: `randomization_date` = **today minus 7 days**. Leave `sms_stop` and `study_withdrawn` unticked. Save.
3. On `contact_info`: `first_name`, `phonen` = your mobile, tick **"SMS to [phonen]"**. Save. No `consent` needed — this alert does not look at it.
4. **Now switch the same record to** **Arm 3: MICA + Weekly SMS** using the arm selector, and open its **Day 1 (ED)** event. The record is now in both arms, which is exactly how a real Arm 3 participant looks.
5. **Save one form at Arm 3's Day 1** — open `admin` there and save it without changing anything. This is rule 2. The reminder belongs to Arm 3's Day 1 and REDCap only checks for it when something is saved at that event. Skip this step and you will get no text and conclude, wrongly, that it is broken.
6. **Do not touch** `mica_ed_session`**.** The reminder only goes to people who have not finished it.
7. Wait 90 seconds and check your phone.

> **PASS** — a text arrives reading *"Hi [your name], it's the MICA Team. Your MICA session is ready (about 20 min): [link] Reply STOP to opt out."*
> **Then tap the link.** It must open the MICA session for *your* record. A link that opens nothing, or someone else's record, is a failure even though the text arrived.

Test 3 Opting out really does stop the texts

Nothing arriving is the pass. This is the protection that matters most. ~4 min

SWITCH ON **03 MICA ED session 1-week reminder (SMS)** — same as test 2

EXPECTED **No text at all.**

1. **New record**, set up exactly as test 2 — details at **Arm 1's** Day 1, backdated 7 days, your mobile, SMS ticked, then moved into Arm 3.
2. **At Arm 1's Day 1**, on `admin`, **tick** `sms_stop`. Save. Arm 1's, not Arm 3's — the alert reads the opt-out at the same event as everything else.
3. Now save a form at **Arm 3's** Day 1, as in test 2 step 5, so the reminder is actually checked for.
4. Wait two minutes.

> **PASS** — no text arrives. Now untick `sms_stop` at Arm 1's Day 1, save, then save at Arm 3's Day 1 again and wait 90 seconds: the text should come through. That second half is what proves the silence was caused by the opt-out and not by something being broken.

> **Do not test this by texting STOP.** It works, but the phone company then blocks your handset for the study until you text START back, and you would not be able to run any further tests. Ticking `sms_stop` is exactly what the alert itself reads.

Test 4 Reminders stop once the participant finishes

If this fails, people who already finished still get chased — worse than no reminders at all ~4 min

SWITCH ON **03 MICA ED session 1-week reminder (SMS)**

EXPECTED **No text at all.**

1. **New record**, set up exactly as test 2 — details at **Arm 1's** Day 1, then moved into Arm 3.
2. **This time complete the session:** at **Arm 3's** Day 1 open `mica_ed_session`, status **Complete**, save. This save doubles as rule 2 — it lands on Arm 3's Day 1, so the reminder is genuinely checked for and genuinely cancelled, rather than never having been considered.
3. Wait two minutes.

> **PASS** — no text arrives. The reminder was due, saw the session was finished, and cancelled itself.

Worth knowing, not worrying about: the cancellation happens on REDCap's once-a-minute check, not the instant you save. So there is a window of up to a minute after a participant finishes in which a reminder could still go out.

Test 5 Three-month booster reminder

Also confirms an Arm 3 participant gets Arm 3's reminder, not Arm 2's ~5 min

SWITCH ON	**11 MICA booster session reminder (SMS, arm 3)**
ARRIVES	Within about 90 seconds.

1. **New record, added in Arm 1.** At **Arm 1's Day 1 (ED)**, on `admin` : `randomization_date` = **today minus 92 days**. Save.
2. Still at **Arm 1's Day 1**, on `contact_info` : `first_name` , `phonen` = your mobile, tick SMS. Save.
3. **Switch the record to** `Arm 3: MICA + Weekly SMS` **.**
4. **Now move to Arm 3's** `Month 3` **event**, open `mica_booster_session` and **save it without completing it** — leave the status Incomplete. Rule 2 again, and this is the test where it bites hardest: the reminder lives on the Month 3 event and REDCap only looks at it when something is saved there. Changing the date at Arm 1's Day 1 will not do it — that was measured. Skip this step and you will conclude it is broken.
5. Wait 90 seconds and check your phone.

> **PASS** — a text arrives reading *"Hi [your name], it's the MICA Team. Your 3-month booster session is ready: [link] Reply STOP to opt out."* Tap the link — it must open the **booster** session, not the Day-1 session.

The weekly 12-week text series

Now configured on the production project, but switched off. The weekly invitation is built and will not send to anyone until the study team switches it on. It runs on a separate module, **Enhanced SMS Conversation**, so the "Surveys and Alerts" setting on page 1 does not affect it. It is not an alert and does not appear under **Alerts & Notifications**.

Texts go only to participants **randomised to Arm 3**, starting the first Sunday at noon after randomisation. Randomisation on production is being fixed separately; until then, the weekly series has no one to send to.

Test 6A The texting line answers

Proves texts reach the study and replies come back. You can do this one alone. ~3 min

SWITCH ON Nothing. This works with the weekly invitation switched off.

YOU NEED The study texting number, which the study team will give you

1. **Add / Edit Records** → arm **Arm 1: Standard Care (SC)** → **Add new record**. Open **Day 1 (ED)** → `contact_info`.
2. `phonen` = **your own mobile number**. Save. Use a number that is on no other record. The line matches your number to a record, and if several share it, the reply is tied to whichever REDCap finds first.
3. From that phone, text **hello** to the study texting number.

PASS — within a few seconds you receive *"Thanks! We will check in soon."* That is the line's automatic answer when no weekly check-in is open.

Text "hello", never STOP or OPTOUT. Those opt your record out of all texts (START reverses it).

Test 6B One real weekly check-in

The actual Sunday conversation, sent to your phone only

~10 min

NEEDS FIRST	Randomisation working on production
STUDY TEAM	Prepares one test record **randomised to Arm 3** with your mobile number and a randomisation date, then switches the weekly invitation on **for that record only**. No participant can be texted.

1. Wait for the study team to tell you it is on. The first text arrives within a minute if the randomisation date is more than a week ago; otherwise it arrives that Sunday at noon.
2. Reply to each text. Suggested answers: **0**, then **Yes**, then **Yes**.
3. Check you received, in order: the greeting with your first name, the drinks question, an alcohol-free message, “Are you planning on drinking…”, the goal question with a number (4 for men, 3 for women), and a closing message.

> **PASS** — the messages arrive in that order, your name and the goal number are filled in (not blank), and your answers appear on the test record's `sunday` form at **Weeks 1–12**, week 1.

Try a different answer path by asking the study team to run another week: for example **3**, **Yes**, **No** (below-limit message, no goal), or **7**, **No** (above-limit message, “Great! Thanks for letting us know.”).

This is what a participant receives each week. Reply by text; the conversation waits for you.

MICA	Hi [first name], it's the MICA Team checking in.
MICA	How many total standard alcohol drinks did you have over the past 7 days?
	you reply with a number
MICA	One tailored message, chosen from the number you gave: **0 drinks** — “Amazing job staying alcohol-free this week!…” **below your limit** — “You reported drinking this week while staying below higher-risk levels…” **at or above your limit** — “This week's drinking was in the range considered unhealthy…”
MICA	Are you planning on drinking alcohol this week?
	you reply Yes or No
MICA	**If No** — “Great! Thanks for letting us know.” and the week ends. **If Yes** — “Would you be willing to commit to a goal to drink N or fewer drinks on any occasion?”
	you reply Yes or No
MICA	One closing message, different for Yes and for No.
MICA	**Week 12 only** — “This completes the text messaging intervention part of the MICA study.”

Every message is different each week — twelve distinct versions of each one, so a participant never sees the same wording twice. That is 63 messages in total; the full library is in the separate message-review document, which is the part we would most like your eye on.

ALSO WORTH KNOWING	DETAIL
Reply window	Leave it more than **60 minutes** and you get a “We missed your response” nudge. After **3 hours** the week closes and waits for the next one.
Cadence	Sundays, twelve times, starting the first Sunday after randomisation. ASPIRE also texted on Thursdays; MICA does not.
Opting out	Replying STOP is designed to stop the weekly texts *and* record the opt-out on the participant's record automatically. We have read this in the module's code but have not yet tested it end to end — do not treat it as verified.

Record what you found

Please note the record number for each test. If a text does not arrive, the two questions we will ask are **“which record?”** and **“what exactly did you type into `randomization_date`, and was it on the first save?”**

TEST	RECORD #	TEXT ARRIVED?	LINK OPENED?	NOTES
1 — passcode text (Arm 1)			n/a	
1 — code accepted (`calc_code_check` = 1)		n/a	n/a	
2 — 1-week session reminder				
3 — opt-out silences it		should be **NO**	n/a	
4 — finishing cancels it		should be **NO**	n/a	
5 — booster reminder				
6A — “hello” gets a reply			n/a	
6B — weekly check-in, right messages			n/a	

> **When you are finished, switch every alert off again** in **Alerts & Notifications**. The study has not gone live, and an alert left on will keep acting on any record anyone creates afterwards.

If something does not work

WHAT YOU SEE	ALMOST ALWAYS
No text on any test	Texting scope is “Surveys only” instead of “Surveys and Alerts”.
Passcode text never arrives	`calcrnd` is blank — see the box in test 1. Or `consent` / `contact_info` left at **Unverified** rather than **Complete**.
No `consent` to open	You are in Arm 3. Test 1 is in **Arm 1**.

WHAT YOU SEE	ALMOST ALWAYS
A timed reminder never arrives	Rule 2 — the date was changed after the first save. Start a new record.
An email arrives instead of a text	Only “Email to [email]” was ticked. Tick the SMS option.
Booster reminder never arrives	Step 3 of test 5 was skipped — something must be saved at the **Month 3** event.
A test worked once, never again	Expected for the passcode: once per record. Create a new record.
Test 6A: no reply to “hello”	Your number isn't saved in `phonen` at Arm 1's Day 1 (another event doesn't count). Otherwise send the study team the time you texted; the texting account's log shows exactly why.
Test 6B: a message shows a blank name or goal number	Stop and tell the study team. The record is missing `first_name` or sex at Arm 1's Day 1.

Anything not on this list — send us the record number and roughly what time you saved. We can see exactly what REDCap decided, and why.